knew the symbolism of sitting in the middle, in the spiritual home of Australian cricket, and events took on a life of their own. The cigars were passed around, and everyone spoke from the heart about what the achievement meant to them.

Sport at the highest level doesn't encourage emotional growth, but no one held back. I was in a panic when it came to my turn to speak, worried about failing to do justice to the magnitude of the moment. Somehow, I came up with the words to express the essence of being an international cricketer.

'Ten weeks ago, I still felt I shouldn't have been selected for this tour,' I said. 'Four months ago, I was one innings away from not being here. Being named man of the series, winning the Ashes, is mad. I've achieved something I didn't think was possible. We have achieved something that will be with us for the rest of our lives.

'So, never give up. No matter how bad it is, never give up. It will turn if you keep doing the right things …'